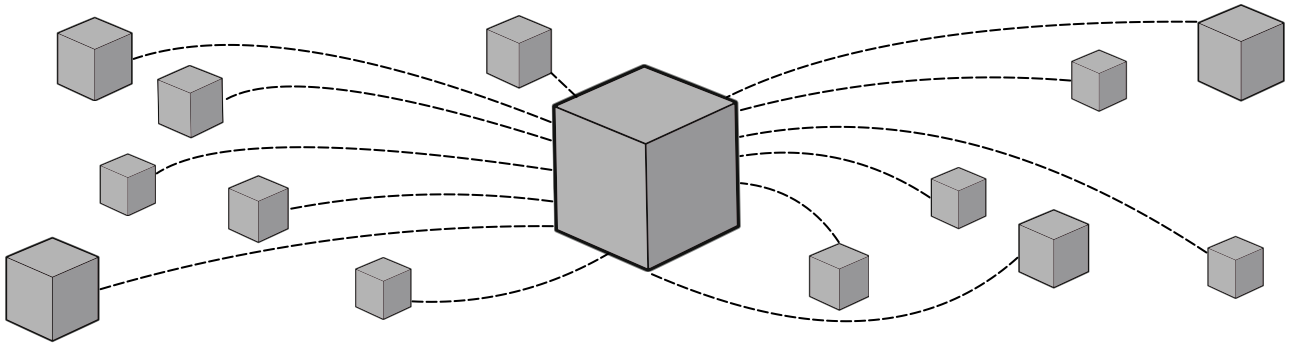


THE MENTAL MOVE

SITUATIONAL TACTICS TO RESET YOUR MIND WHEN EMOTIONS
SPIKE, STAKES RISE, OR CLARITY SHATTERS



This collection combines AI-assisted composition with human introspection. Every piece started out as a late-night idea, a fleeting emotion that AI shaped slightly and perfected. These are only glimpses of emotion and silent moments caught between dream and thought; they are not absolutes.

The book is divided into eight sections, with combined total of thirty-five plays. Each composition consists of four brief lines that are followed by three closing lines, creating a brief cycle of introspection and reaction.

These are not responses. Simple moments given form through words, they are pauses, enquiries, and nighttime echoes of the mind.

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THIS ISSUE BELONGS TO LEAF, A SERIES OF NUMBERED MINI BOOKS
EXPLORING INDIVIDUAL INSIGHTS.

LEAF 05

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HOW TO ACTUALLY USE THIS BOOK

FINAL NOTE

INTRODUCTION

You are not expected to commit it to memory on a daily basis. Consider these 35 plays as if you had 35 different tools in your pocket that you don't always use. When the situation demands it, you use them.

It is not personality that distinguishes someone who breaks under pressure from someone who doesn't. It's the ability to make a better mental move at a crucial time.

You have a move when your boss surprises you (play 2: Reverse Blame).

You have a move when things seem urgent (play 1: Zoom-Out).

You have a move when your anxiety is getting out of control (play 21: Time Box the Spiral).

Stoic philosophy, cognitive behavioral therapy, decision science, and simply real life are the sources of inspiration for these plays. Not life on Instagram. Not the one in which everything is flawless. The one where you need to think more clearly for the next five minutes and you're exhausted, perplexed, and possibly a little angry.

The plays are grouped logically together. Utilize them. You can disregard the ones that don't apply to you. Mark the ones that hit in a different way. The goal is not to become a serene robot or a monk. If your default action of Defend, Blame, or Freeze doesn't work, you should have other options.

SECTION I: SEEING CLEARLY

PLAY 1: ZOOM-OUT PLAY

The Move:

"Will this matter in 6 months?" ask yourself.

Put your action on hold if the answer is not clear.

Why It Works:

The majority of panic is present-oriented. Your brain is unable to discriminate between a perceived threat and an actual emergency. Even though one is actually manageable, receiving a critical email from your boss feels as dangerous as having your car break down.

The 6-month frame is magical because it is both close enough to feel authentic and far enough away to provide perspective. "Will this matter in 10 years?" is not the question. (which is too ethereal). It's particular. It can be tested.

Something changes when you ask this question honestly. Either you come to the realization that "No, this won't matter," or your nervous system calms down. Or you come to the realization that "Yes, actually it will matter"—and that realization actually improves your behavior because you are aware of the seriousness of the situation.

How to Use It:

Don't ask yourself ambiguous questions. Make it tangible. Take out your phone and ask yourself, "Will me not responding to this email right now matter in 6 months?" if necessary. The answer is frequently no. If the answer is yes, you'll be able to make a better choice and at least understand why this is truly crucial.

The actual tool in this situation is the pause. The majority of errors occur between the stimulus and the response. That gap is widened by this play.

When It Fails:

When there is an immediate threat to your safety, this is ineffective (don't zoom out when a car is speeding at you). Additionally, if you're already in a state of total panic, it doesn't work because your brain is unable to access logical time frames. Play 25 (Physical Reset) should be used first.

PLAY 2: REVERSE BLAME PLAY

The Move:

When a disagreement arises, assume that you were the first to misunderstand. Next, reevaluate the circumstances.

Why It Works:

Immediate defence is our default strategy. When someone says something hurtful, we immediately create a story in which we are correct and they are incorrect. Because it feels like survival, our brain does this on autopilot.

However, most of the time—though not always—we're missing something. We either misheard them. Or we don't fully comprehend their context. Or we're using our own emotional state to interpret their tone.

Reverse blaming does not imply that you are always at fault. Instead of thinking, "They're attacking me," try thinking, "I'm probably misunderstanding this." Even though it's just a change in direction, everything is altered.

How to Use It:

Pause when someone says something that doesn't make sense. Say: "Wait, I might be getting this wrong," either silently or aloud, depending on the situation. I'd like to know what they truly meant.

As an illustration, your spouse remarks, "You never help with the house." By default, it says, "They're being unfair and dramatic." Reverse Blame stated: "Maybe I'm not seeing the effort they're putting in, or maybe we have different standards for what counts as 'helping.'"

This does not negate the fact that you were correct. It simply means that before you defend, you obtain more accurate information.

When It Fails:

If someone is actually attempting to control you, this breaks. This should not be used as an excuse for people to ignore you. Instead of becoming a doormat, the play is about gaining clarity. You have accurate information if you reverse the blame and the harsh message remains the same.

PLAY 3: NEUTRAL OBSERVER SHIFT

The Move:

Describe your circumstances as though they were someone else's.

Make use of the third person. Describe what you see in detail.

Why It Works:

You cannot see something's shape when you are in the middle of it. You're too near. The perceiving is being done by your emotions. However, something shifts when you take a step back and describe it as if you were an outsider. When you were living it, you were blind to the patterns.

The practice of *prosoche*, or "mindful attention," is directly related to stoic philosophy. The Stoics understood that seeing clearly is impeded by emotional entanglement. However, distance (even imagined distance) brings clarity back.

How to Use It:

When you find yourself in a loop (doubting, spiralling, obsessing), tell it aloud or in the third person on paper: Right now, someone is in their flat. During a meeting, they made a mistake. They keep playing it over and over. They are creating narratives based on everyone's opinions. However, no one is genuinely considering it anymore. They have their own story and are by themselves.

The grip loosens as soon as you can see that clearly. It dawns on you that what you're doing to yourself isn't being done to you.

When It Fails:

This may feel too detached if you're actually in danger or experiencing a crisis. To exit fight-or-flight mode, use play 25 (Physical Reset) before using this.

PLAY 4: ENERGY AUDIT PLAY

The Move:

Ask yourself, "Do I have the energy for the consequence?" before making any commitments.

Why It Works:

The majority of our decisions fail because we lack the energy to carry them out, not because they are poor choices. You accept a project. You are capable of handling the project. However, you lack the ability to handle the fallout—the follow-up discussions, the paperwork, and the emotional strain if something goes wrong.

This play compels you to consider "can I sustain this decision?" rather than just "can I do this task?" It's the distinction between execution and planning.

How to Use It:

Actual situation: You are asked to mentor someone. Your initial reaction was, "Yes, I can help." The Energy Audit: "Do I have the mental energy for weekly check-ins, for caring about someone else's progress, for having difficult conversations if they're not improving?" Perhaps the answer is in the affirmative. Perhaps it's "not right now."

It is not selfish to refuse something because you truly lack the energy to deal with its repercussions. It's truthful. Honesty also keeps people from becoming resentful.

When It Fails:

Emergencies and non-optional circumstances are not covered by this. However, it works for the majority of your actual choices.

PLAY 5: DELAY RESPONSE PLAY

The Move:

Don't react right away when feelings are running high.

Put off responding. Being silent is an active action rather than a passive one.

Why It Works:

An irate brain makes bad choices. Defensive decisions are made by a damaged brain. Aggressive decisions are made by a threatened brain. But a cool head? that determines strategic choices.

Your power resides in the space between stimulus and response. The majority of people are unaware that they have that gap. They believe that responses happen instantly. However, it isn't. If you know how, you can make room.

How to Use It:

Your natural reaction is to react right away when someone says something hurtful to defend, explain, or retaliate. Rather, take no action. That day, don't reply. Frequently, not even the following day.

This has nothing to do with being cold or calculating. It's about preventing your worst self from making long-term choices. Your perspective changes after you've given it 24 hours, 48 hours, or a week. When you were reactive, you missed opportunities.

When It Fails:

Certain circumstances necessitate an instant reaction (confrontation, fact clarification, preventing misinformation). Even so, you can postpone responding while you're there. You don't have to be reactive to be there.

PLAY 6: NAME THE COST

The Move:

When you're about to make a decision, be clear about the costs.

Write it down or say it aloud.

Why It Works:

Your brain is very good at concealing expenses. Your brain conceals the price because you want the promotion: "less time with family, higher stress, more politics." Your brain conceals the cost of skipping the workout by saying things like "you're getting slower, your sleep quality drops."

However, the spell breaks as soon as you state the price clearly. You are no longer able to pretend. Knowing what you're trading, you're making a decision.

This does not imply that you should avoid making difficult decisions. Making them with an open mind is what it means.

How to Use It:

Before you commit: "It will cost me Thursdays with my children if I accept this job. Sleep for two hours every night. the room in my mind to engage in my pastime. My perception of my own abilities.

Or: "I will lose trust in this relationship if I avoid this conversation." My own integrity. When it comes up again, there will probably be more suffering."

Your choice isn't always altered by giving it a name. However, it alters how you relate to your choice. You are no longer deceiving yourself about the cost.

When It Fails:

If you use it to talk yourself out of everything, it can be crippling. It's should be like lucidity not like veto.

PLAY 7: WORST-CASE ACCEPTANCE

The Move:

Calmly accept the worst possible scenario.
Then observe that the power of fear diminishes.

Why It Works:

Because fear resides in maybe, it has great power. Perhaps your reputation is ruined. Perhaps you fall short in front of everyone. Perhaps you wind up by yourself. Because these fantasies are nameless, ill-defined, and somehow worse than reality, they feel dangerous.

However, something changes when you pull back the curtain and consider the worst scenario—not as a fantasy but as "here's what would actually happen, and here's how I would handle it." You see, I could make it through this.

When done properly, this fundamental Stoic technique known as premeditatio malorum (negative visualisation) is not torture. It's getting ready. It's empowerment.

How to Use It:

You're scared, but you want to start something. Request: "What's the absolute worst that happens?" The real worst, not the fantasy.

The worst-case scenario for starting a business is that it fails, you lose your savings, and you have to return to a day job. Would you be able to manage that? Most likely, yes. Although it's uncomfortable, it's manageable.

When you speak up in a meeting, the worst-case scenario is that you say something awkward, a few people notice, the moment goes by, and everyone forgets. Would you be able to manage that? Indeed.

When It Fails:

You need a plan, not acceptance, if your worst-case scenario is truly catastrophic (health crisis, real danger). Talk to someone or use Play 25 (Physical Reset).

PLAY 8: ONE-SENTENCE TRUTH

The Move:

Compress the whole issue into one honest sentence.

No qualifiers, no hedging.

Why It Works:

You have a tendency to spiral when you're confused or conflicted. There are seventeen distinct perspectives, explanations, exceptions, and reasons. Your thoughts turn into a ball of yarn. That is cut through by one-sentence truth.

It compels you to distinguish the real problem from all the surrounding noise. You don't fully comprehend something when you can't put it into a single, coherent sentence.

How to Use It:

Tangled process of thought: "Well, I'm not sure if I should do this because on one hand it's good experience but on the other hand I'm really tired and I don't know if I have the focus, plus I've been saying yes to too much, but this is a unique opportunity..."

The truth in one sentence: "I don't actually want to do this right now."
That's all. You are aware now. Instead of all the noise, you can now act from something genuine.

Another instance: Tangled: "I love them but they sometimes do things that bother me and I don't want to be difficult but I also deserve to be treated well..."

Truth in one sentence: "I need to have a conversation about boundaries."
Simplified: "This relationship needs something I'm not getting."

When It Fails:

Certain circumstances are truly complicated. Beneath the complexity, however, is typically a true core statement. If you are unable to locate it, you most likely need to think more (or obtain a different viewpoint).

SECTION 2: BREAKING STAGNATION

PLAY 9: DO THE SMALLEST IRREVERSIBLE ACTION

The Move:

Make the smallest movement to get past the cubicle while you're frozen. It must be manageable for today. It needs to be irreversible.

Why It Works:

Being immobile is not typically the cause of stagnation. It has to do with the initial step feeling excessively large. Thus, you don't move at all. However, the spell is broken by a small, irreversible action. You commit to it. It generates momentum. It demonstrates to you that you are not genuinely frozen.

How to Use It:

"I want to change careers but I'm overwhelmed."

Emailing one person in the industry you're interested in is the smallest irreversible action you can take. Only one. It's not a big request. Just "Hey, I'm considering going into this industry." Would you be willing to have a quick chat?"

"I want to improve my fitness but I don't know where to start."

Purchasing a single pair of shoes for walking or running is the smallest irreversible action. Not a membership. Only shoes. Something that reads, "I committed to this." and is kept in your closet

"I'm considering breaking up with someone, but I'm afraid."

Write them a message, the smallest irreversible action. Sending it is not required. However, the process of writing it and deciding what you want to say is irreversible. It moves you from contemplating it to taking action.

When It Fails:

If you're attempting to make a significant life change without giving it much thought, this won't work. To get clear, start with play 8. Then make use of this to move.

PLAY 10: VALUE CHECK PLAY

The Move:

Ask yourself, "Would I respect myself after this?" before you do anything.

Why It Works:

The majority of regrets are not related to significant setbacks. They are about minor betrayals of oneself. You acted in a way that was inconsistent with your true self. You did it even though you knew better.

This play incorporates your values into the choice. Your genuine respect for yourself, not impersonal ideals. Because you can sense respect. It's not an abstract concept.

How to Use It:

You're going to spread rumours about someone. "Will I respect myself tomorrow if I do this?" is a value check. The typical response is "No, not really." Information is that response.

You're going to forego something crucial in order to prevent discomfort. Value Check: "Will I respect myself for taking the easy way out?" Usually, the answer is "No."

You're going to have to be honest about something challenging. Value Check: "Will I respect myself if I say this, even if it's uncomfortable?" Usually, the answer is "Yes."

When It Fails:

This presupposes that you already have values to compare. You can't use this if you don't know what you value. Take some time to consider that first.

PLAY 11: BOREDOM SIT

The Move:

Don't give in to the temptation to run away from boredom.

Take a seat with it. Look at it. Hold on.

Why It Works:

You've been trained by modern life to quickly avoid boredom. Snack, phone, stimulation, and distraction. However, boredom is actually attempting to convey a message to you. Avoidance (you're avoiding something), restlessness (you're truly not engaged), or clarity (your brain is trying to process something) are the three main causes of boredom.

You discover which one it is if you are unable to flee. And everything is altered by that.

How to Use It:

You take a seat and get to work. You're bored after ten minutes. Your gut tells you to check your phone, grab a cup of coffee, or start something else.

Sit for five more minutes if you're bored. Avoid getting sidetracked. Take note of the boredom.

What frequently occurs is a shift in boredom. Perhaps you become aware that you are, in fact, avoiding something difficult (the boredom is avoidance). Or you become aware that you need to alter your surroundings or strategy (the boredom is a signal). Or, after the boredom wears off, you're genuinely engaged (it was just resistance).

When It Fails:

You're most likely engaged in the wrong activity if you've been sitting for twenty minutes and nothing has changed. To switch between environments, use play 16 (Context Switch).

PLAY 12: DROP THE PERFORMANCE

The Move:

Give up trying to look professional, calm, or cohesive. Simply carry out the task.

Why It Works:

When it comes to competence, most people waste 20% of their energy. straightening your posture as the boss passes by. being prepared with the solution even when you are unsure. laughing at unfunny jokes. maintaining composure when you're genuinely perplexed.

It's a tiring performance. Additionally, it hinders real learning and connection.

How to Use It:

Say, "I'm not following," in a meeting rather than attempting to appear thoughtful while utterly disoriented. Are you able to back up?

Say something like, "I've never done this before," rather than acting like you know how to do it. Take me through it.

Show up as you are when you're having difficulties rather than trying to maintain a straight face. Not ostentatious or attention-grabbing. Just genuine.

It turns out that people value authenticity more than competent performance. Additionally, you can stop exerting yourself on the act.

When It Fails:

A hint of professionalism can be helpful in certain situations (such as formal presentations or job interviews). Even so, lowering the performance is the aim. You don't have to be fake to be professional.

SECTION 3: WHEN EVERYTHING AGREES

PLAY 13: CONTRARIAN PAUSE

The Move:

Hesitate if everyone agrees right away. Examine your own reasoning. There may be something lacking.

Why It Works:

One of two things can occur when a room comes to a consensus too quickly: either everyone is missing something because no one is exercising critical thought (common), or the consensus is genuinely correct and straightforward (rare).

How to Use It:

Your group comes to a decision right away. No resistance. Everyone is in agreement. Your first reaction was relief. Instead, use this play: pause. Ask specifically: "What are we missing? What could someone find objectionable?"

Everyone says you should do something in your personal life, but your gut tells you, "Okay, I guess that's the answer." Consider this question: "What's actually true for me, separate from this consensus?"

When It Fails:

Some things really are simple and everyone correctly agrees. But the pause costs almost nothing, so use it anyway.

PLAY 14: EMOTION LABELING

The Move:

Put the emotion on paper or say it aloud. precise label rather than ambiguous.

Why It Works:

You distance yourself from something when you give it a name. Rather than saying "I feel bad," you say "I feel disappointed and also anxious about the outcome." All of a sudden, it is no longer a cloud. You can take a look at it.

This is a component of controlling emotions. What your brain cannot recognise, it cannot control.

How to Use It:

Something someone says in a meeting goes awry. Rather than allowing it to worsen, take a moment to label it as "I'm feeling dismissed right now" or "I'm feeling afraid that I made a mistake."

You can inspect it once you've labelled it. Is it true? Is there a pattern? Does it provide insight into your needs?

When It Fails:

This doesn't alter the emotion. It simply makes it feasible. Play 25 (Physical Reset) if you identify the emotion and it's still overwhelming.

PLAY 15: SHORT MEMORY RESET

The Move:

Refuse to make the same mistakes you made yesterday.

Every day is a fresh start.

Why It Works:

By default, your brain keeps files open. to continue processing. to continue playing. From an evolutionary perspective, this made sense: keep in mind what went wrong to avoid repeating it. However, in today's world, it simply means that you're punishing yourself for hours after the incident is over.

You are authorised to close the file by this play.

How to Use It:

You made an uncomfortable statement yesterday. You've spent the entire night playing it again. You consciously reset when you woke up today: "That happened." I witnessed it. It's finished now. It's a new day.

You can still learn from it despite this. It implies that self-flagellation does not exacerbate the harm.

When It Fails:

You really should consider the pattern if you continue to make the same error (use play 31: Pattern Recognition). However, compulsive replaying does not constitute thought. It's agony.

SECTION 4: SHIFTING PERSPECTIVE

PLAY 16: CONTEXT SWITCH

The Move:

Prior to making a decision or taking action, shift your physical location.
New clarity, new space.

Why It Works:

Your surroundings shape the way you think. As you sit at your desk, your thoughts continue to repeat themselves. When you relocate to a new space, your perspective changes. It's not magic. Your brain uses context to process information.

How to Use It:

You're having trouble making a choice. Spend thirty minutes thinking while seated at your desk. Nothing. Next, stroll over to a coffee shop. Clearer all of a sudden. Or take a seat somewhere else. or step outside.

The surroundings are more than just background. It is a component of your way of thinking.

When It Fails:

Moving won't help if the issue is physical (you're hungry, exhausted, or in pain). Prioritise fixing the physical.

PLAY 17: SILENT COMPLETION

The Move:

Complete a task without informing anyone.

No credit-taking, no announcement.

Why It Works:

Most of our actions involve a subconscious performance: we do something, then we tell someone about it to receive praise or validation. However, that is draining. It links your action to feedback from outside sources.

That cycle is broken by silent completion. You don't do it for the story you'll tell about it, but rather for the object itself.

How to Use It:

Say, "I'm not following," in a meeting rather than attempting to appear thoughtful while utterly disoriented. Are you able to back up?

Say something like, "I've never done this before," rather than acting like you know how to do it. Take me through it.

Show up as you are when you're having difficulties rather than trying to maintain a straight face. Not ostentatious or attention-grabbing. Just genuine.

It turns out that people value authenticity more than competent performance. Additionally, you can stop exerting yourself on the act.

When It Fails:

In professional settings, you may occasionally need to convey completion so that someone can utilise or expand upon your work. That isn't a performance. That's useful.

PLAY 18: FUTURE-SELF DIALOGUE

The Move:

"Which version of myself gains from this decision?" Which version is worse?

Why It Works:

You are not a single individual. There are several incarnations of you over time. Your future self in five minutes. Your self in five years. Your self in fifty years. Their needs are different.

When you make a decision, it affects everyone. You are forced to think about them by this play.

How to Use It:

You want to scroll through the night. This is what your five-minute self desires. You'll be exhausted tomorrow. The consequences of your version in five years will be... unclear, but most likely not good.

The option is not to "don't scroll." Whose needs are more important at the moment? Prioritising your 5-minute self is acceptable at times. However, at least you're doing it intentionally.

When It Fails:

You must be concerned about your future self in order to do this. This play won't succeed if you don't. However, most people do, on some level. It's just made clear in this play.

PLAY 19: ONE-LAYER DEEPER

The Move:

Ask "why?" just once, not repeatedly.

Locate the layer beneath, then come to a stop.

Why It Works:

When you're confused, you spiral by asking why infinitely. "Why did I do that?" "Because I was anxious." "Why am I anxious?" "Because I'm afraid of failing..." And on and on. This creates a spiral, not clarity.

But one layer deeper is usually enough. Go one layer below the surface, see what's there, then make your decision.

How to Use It:

During a conversation, you were defensive. Why right away: "Because they criticised me." A level higher: "Because I felt my competence was being questioned and I needed to protect myself."

That's sufficient. That reveals something genuine. Therapy work goes deeper ("And why do I need to protect my competence?"). One layer is sufficient for making decisions.

When It Fails:

You may require real therapy or coaching if the one layer still doesn't provide you with clarity. However, one layer is adequate for the majority of current decisions.

PLAY 20: REMOVE THE AUDIENCE

The Move:

Make a decision as if nobody would ever find out.

Not carelessly. Just without the viewers.

Why It Works:

Many of the choices we make are really choices about our appearance. What are people going to think? What will it look like? Our decision-making process has been delegated to a fictional audience.

What do you really want, though, if nobody is looking?

How to Use It:

You're considering changing careers. "What will people say? Will they think I failed at my old thing?" is the audience version. "Do I actually want this?" in the audience-removed version

You're considering establishing a limit. "Will they think I'm difficult?" is the audience version. Version with the audience removed: "Do I need this boundary?"

The audience-removed response is typically more understandable. Additionally, it occasionally matches the audience's response, which is acceptable. At least you are aware of the true motivations behind your actions.

When It Fails:

The needs of others are legitimately taken into consideration when making certain decisions. In those situations, the audience cannot be totally eliminated. However, before you consider everyone else, you can at least clarify what you truly want.

SECTION 5: STOPPING THE SPIRAL

PLAY 21: TIME BOX THE SPIRAL

The Move:

Give yourself ten minutes to worry.

Then stop on purpose.

Why It Works:

Anxiety cannot be eradicated by ignoring it. That simply makes it more powerful. However, you are able to control it. After giving it a certain amount of time, shut the door.

How to Use It:

There's something to be concerned about. Set a timer for 10 minutes of real worry instead of attempting to avoid thinking about it, which causes you to think about it more. Allow your mind to go crazy. Consider the worst situations. Take it out.

Stop after ten minutes. You're finished. You've had enough time to process this. There was a time for the spiral.

When It Fails:

This becomes a never-ending source of concern if you keep resetting the timer. Thus, one timer is the rule. Just once. Even if it doesn't feel complete, you then stop.

PLAY 22: STOP SEEKING CLOSURE

The Move:

There are still some unanswered questions. Acknowledge it.
Go anyhow.

Why It Works:

Your mind seeks resolution. wants to be understood. desires a tidy conclusion to the tale. However, it doesn't always. Sometimes it's impossible to know what someone was thinking. There are times when you will never know why something occurred. And without that, you have to move on.

Accepting that some files remain open is the theme of this play.

How to Use It:

You and someone were at odds. They refuse to give an explanation. You can't stop waiting for comprehension. I may never know what they were thinking, so stop and accept that. I still have to move on.

You regret what you did. You're looking for a moment of redemption or closure. However, that isn't always the case in life. Without the closure, move on.

When It Fails:

If you are avoiding legitimate processing, this is ineffective. You still need to consider it and experience your emotions (plays 14, 21). However, this play is about letting go once you've accomplished that.

PLAY 23: MINIMAL TRUTH ADMISSION

The Move:

Only acknowledge what is required.

No justification, no elaboration, and no oversharing.

Why It Works:

We often overshare when we're defensive or ashamed. We tell the whole story, defend ourselves, and explain everything. However, this frequently exacerbates the situation. There is more room for misunderstanding when there is more information available.

How to Use It:

When you make a mistake, someone notices. Your gut tells you to minimise the damage by talking a lot, explain everything, and justify why it happened.

Minimal Admission of Truth: "You're correct. I erred. I'll make it right."

That's all. No further explanation. No explanation. No story.

When It Fails:

In certain situations, an explanation is required (to understand how to prevent it next time). However, oversharing is not the same as explanation. An explanation is helpful. Sharing too much is defensive.

SECTION 6: SEEING WHAT'S REWARDED

PLAY 24: REVERSE INCENTIVE CHECK

The Move:

Ask yourself: "What behaviour is this situation rewarding, even if I don't intend it?"

Why It Works:

You take action because you believe it is the best course of action. However, you continue doing the ineffective behaviour because your circumstances are actually rewarding the opposite behaviour.

The hidden incentives are revealed in this play.

How to Use It:

You join a gym in an effort to improve your health. However, the circumstances (pricey membership, awkward location, feeling uncomfortable) are actually encouraging the opposite behavior—not attending.

You open up to someone because you want deeper relationships. However, the circumstances (disregarding your emotions and spreading rumours about you) are actually encouraging the behaviour you don't want—remaining closed off.

You can alter the incentive structure once you've seen it.

When It Fails:

Sometimes the incentives are stacked against you, and you need to alter not just your behaviour but the entire situation. You can see that through this play.

PLAY 25: PHYSICAL RESET

The Move:

Reset your body when your mind becomes stuck.

Walk, change your posture, breathe, and use cold water.

Why It Works:

Your body and mind are one and the same. Your body becomes tense, your breathing becomes shallow, and your posture collapses when your mind is in fight-or-flight mode. In that state, you are unable to think clearly.

However, your mental state changes as soon as your physical state does.

How to Use It:

You're nervous. splashing your face with cold water. strolls fifty yards. Your nervous system settles right away.

You're stuck. Get up, adjust your posture, and perform ten push-ups. Blood moves. Clarity comes back.

You're upset. Fill your belly with a deep breath, not a shallow one. Your fight-or-flight reaction becomes less active.

When It Fails:

It's a reset. It's not a remedy. You need real support if you're experiencing real trauma or severe anxiety. However, a physical reset is effective for everyday mental stagnation.

PLAY 26: REFUSE BINARY THINKING

The Move:

When faced with a choice between two options, look for a third.
It is usually present.

Why It Works:

Your brain prefers to think in binary terms. Remain or depart. Take a chance or be cautious. Talk to them or remain silent. However, there are typically more than two choices in real-world scenarios. All you have to do is look more closely.

How to Use It:

"Should I quit my job or stay?" Binary question. Third options include negotiating better terms, taking a sabbatical, changing roles, or beginning a side project while working.

Should I let it go or confront them? Binary. Third options, however, include establishing a distance, addressing it indirectly, and setting a boundary without engaging in direct conflict.

When It Fails:

Certain circumstances are truly binary (you can't be slightly pregnant). However, the majority aren't.

SECTION 7: LONG-TERM STRATEGY

PLAY 27: PLAY THE LONG GAME

The Move:

Give up immediate relief in favour of long-term stability.

Understand which option you're selecting and why.

Why It Works:

The majority of our worst choices are made with short-term comfort in mind. Damage the relationship (long-term cost) and avoid the difficult conversation (short-term relief). Steer clear of the exercise (short-term comfort), and you'll feel worse later (long-term cost).

That reasoning is reversed when you play the long game. Because it results in long-term stability, you accept the short-term discomfort.

How to Use It:

You could feel relieved today by avoiding this challenging feedback discussion. But when the issue worsens in six months, you'll regret it.

You could feel at ease now and forego the workout. However, if your fitness declines in a month, you'll feel worse.

When It Fails:

Playing the long game alone makes you unhappy. There are instances when temporary relief is worthwhile. However, the majority of us prioritise the short term too much. That imbalance is corrected in this play.

PLAY 28: MISALIGNMENT DETECTION

The Move:

Reevaluate your course if something quickly depletes your energy.
Information is sustained fatigue.

Why It Works:

Sustainable things seem to need work but don't run out. Things that are not sustainable make you feel as though your life is being drained.

If a relationship or job is difficult, it doesn't necessarily mean you're in the wrong one. That's information, though, if it's exhausting.

How to Use It:

Your work is demanding yet stimulating. It is sustainable. Your work is depleting your motivation to live. That is not sustainable. Something else entirely.

Although your relationship is labour-intensive, it feels like a partnership. sustainable. You're in a relationship where you have to hide yourself or control their emotions all the time. not sustainable.

When It Fails:

Any difficult thing (new job, new skill, new relationship) has a taxing first phase. Therefore, avoid using this play during the initial weeks. However, you can eventually distinguish between "challenging and draining" and "difficult but ultimately energising."

PLAY 29: INTENTIONAL UNDERREACTION

The Move:

Choose calm when drama is an option.

Make a conscious decision.

Why It Works:

People in your immediate vicinity frequently offer you drama. Someone is dramatic, someone is upset, and someone wants you to respond. You have the option to enter or exit that.

Making the decision to leave is an intentional underreaction. Not in a chilly manner. Not contemptuously. Just... quietly.

How to Use It:

You receive an irate email from someone. Drama options include responding angrily, matching their intensity, and escalating.

Underreaction on purpose: read it, take your time, and respond in a measured manner.

In a meeting, someone is upset about something. Take sides, get sentimental, and make it all about yourself in this drama.

Underreaction on purpose: remain composed, pay attention, and avoid adding fuel to the flames.

When It Fails:

You're not being calm; rather, you're being passive if you underreact to actual danger or disrespect. Drama is optional in this situation. Make use of it there.

PLAY 30: MICRO-EXIT

The Move:

Choose calm when drama is an option.

Make a conscious decision.

Why It Works:

Have you ever been in social settings or under pressure at work for an extended period of time, and then all of a sudden you're worn out and agitated and everything falls apart?

Leaving ten minutes before that occurs is known as micro-exit.

How to Use It:

You're at a gathering. You're feeling fine. You have three more hours to stay. Micro-exit: Get out while you're still feeling good.

There is a meeting going on. You continue to track. However, you are aware that in half an hour you will lose it. Micro-exit: excuse yourself, go outside, and take a break.

You're having a discussion. Everything is going smoothly. Micro-exit: Don't let it drag and deteriorate; end it while it's still good.

When It Fails:

You will never develop resilience if you micro-exit every time something becomes a little awkward. When you truly feel like you're getting close to your limit, use this.

SECTION 8: PATTERN WORK

PLAY 31: PATTERN RECOGNITION PLAY

The Move:

Request: "Where have I seen this before?"

Instead of focusing only on the circumstances, look for the pattern.

Why It Works:

The majority of your experiences are recurring. Different person, same conflict. The same challenge in a different setting. You can intervene in a different way if you are able to recognise the pattern.

How to Use It:

Someone at work and you are at odds. Enquire: Where have I previously seen this? Perhaps you are aware of this: "I always get defensive when someone questions my competence." You are aware of the pattern now. You can stop that pattern before you react the next time.

You continue to select unhealthy circumstances. Find out what the pattern is. Perhaps: "I gravitate toward people who need fixing." The pattern is that. You can now search for circumstances that deviate from that pattern.

When It Fails:

False patterns (coincidence, not pattern) can occasionally be observed. Verify if this has appeared at least three or four times. If so, there is most likely a true pattern.

PLAY 32: STOP EXPLAINING

The Move:

Authority is frequently weakened by explanation.

After stating your position, cease.

Why It Works:

You explain when you're insecure but correct about something. You go into too much detail. You continue to speak in an attempt to persuade others that you are correct.

However, each additional sentence you use after making your point actually makes you weaker. It appears defensive. It appears uncertain.

How to Use It:

A boundary you've established is disputed by someone. Your gut tells you to justify the boundary. However, that is requesting permission. Rather, say, "State the boundary, stop." No justification. I'm not available to talk about this at this time."

(Pause. Avoid saying things like "because I'm busy," "because I've had a long day," or "because this isn't a good time."

When It Fails:

Explanation is helpful in educational settings or when you are sincerely attempting to assist someone in understanding. However, additional justification weakens you in power dynamics when you're making a choice or establishing a boundary.

PLAY 33: DO IT POORLY ON PURPOSE

The Move:

Do something poorly on purpose to break your perfectionism.

Give up striving for perfection.

Why It Works:

Procrastination wearing a good-guy mask is a common manifestation of perfectionism. "I want to do this perfectly, so I do nothing." But almost always, done is preferable to perfect.

If you intentionally do it poorly, the spell is broken. It reads, "I'm willing to do this thing imperfectly."

How to Use It:

You want to start writing, but you're stuck because each sentence must be flawless. Make a bad first draft on purpose. intentionally. Badly. See for yourself that it's not as disastrous as you initially believed.

You want to start exercising, but you're afraid you won't be able to do it "right." Do it badly on purpose: go to the gym and work out poorly and with little enthusiasm. intentionally. Badly. Observe: No one is concerned. You did not pass away. You've only just begun.

When It Fails:

Don't use this for fields like teaching, financial advising, or surgery where quality is truly important. Perfectionism, however, is the true enemy for the majority of what you're avoiding.

PLAY 34: LET IT BE UNFINISHED

The Move:

Recognise that some tasks don't need to be finished.

It's acceptable to be incomplete.

Why It Works:

Your mind seeks resolution. Finalisation. the satisfying conclusion. However, not everything is worth finishing.

There are books that are not worth finishing. Certain projects are unnecessary. There are some ideas that don't require action. You are given permission to stop by this play.

How to Use It:

Six months ago, you began a project. It won't go away. Your gut tells you to finish it in order to avoid being "a quitter."

Leave it unfinished. Actually, it's alright. You are not served by it. Give it up.

You began reading a popular book. For you, it's not landing. Your gut tells you to keep going because you should finish your books.

Leave it unfinished. Go read something else.

When It Fails:

This isn't for you if you tend to give up on things when they become difficult. However, this play is liberating if you tend to put things off because you "should" finish them.

PLAY 35: INNER ALIGNMENT CHECK

The Move:

Pause if your body, mind, and values don't agree.

Wait until they are in alignment before moving.

Why It Works:

Sometimes, even though your mind says "yes," your body says "no." You feel uncomfortable. It appears that your morals have been compromised. When these three are out of alignment, you will encounter discord.

This play says, "Don't override it." Conflict is a source of knowledge.

How to Use It:

You think, "This is a great opportunity, I should take it."

Your body tells you that you are tense, have trouble sleeping, and are worried about it all the time.

According to your values, you have to make compromises that you don't want to.

Don't accept it. There is no alignment.

Or:

It says to you, "I'm not sure if this is right."

Your body communicates that you are focused, at ease, and full of energy.

According to your values, this is in line with your priorities.

Take action. There is alignment.

When It Fails:

There is always some misalignment in the early stages of difficult things. Even though starting a business is in line with your values, it still feels scary (body). That's typical. Instead of using this play for initial resistance, use it for persistent misalignment.

HOW TO ACTUALLY USE THIS BOOK

You can't just read this once and incorporate it. Choose a play that speaks to you. Put it to use for a week. Take note of what occurs. Add one more play after that.

The plays are effective because they are specific (made for a specific moment) and straightforward (you can hold them in your head).

It is your responsibility to identify when a play is needed and then carry it out. That's all.

You'll make a mistake. You'll react poorly and forget to use the play, but five hours later you'll remember it. That's typical. Perfection is not the aim. When your default response isn't working, you have options.

Start with the plays that speak to you right away. Ignore those that don't. Later, return to the others.

Probably the most potent plays in this book are:

- **Play 1 (Zoom-Out):** To reduce anxiety.
- **Play 5 (Delay Response):** For reactivity.
- **Play 8 (One-Sentence Truth):** To avoid misunderstandings.
- **Play 27 (Play the Long Game):** To make quick choices.
- **Play 35 (Inner Alignment Check):** To determine your true desires.

However, each person is unique. Your strongest plays may be entirely different.

Make reference to this book. Save pages to your bookmarks. Make annotations. Take ownership of it.

And keep in mind that the objective is not to become someone who never faces difficulties. Being a person with options when hardship arises is the aim.

The majority of this capability is already yours. These plays simply make it more approachable.

FINAL NOTE

To be clear, none of these plays will feel "natural" when you use them for the first time. They might feel uncomfortable, laborious, and possibly even phoney.

That's right. That's how each play operates.

Play 5 (Delay Response) will seem forced to you the first time you use it. You'll feel compelled to reply right away. It will feel strange to remain silent.

However, a week later? It gets simpler. After a month? It starts to happen automatically.

Like any other skill, these are mental abilities/thoughts . They need to be practiced. At first, they feel strange. Then they don't.

This is not a therapeutic book. It won't address your deeper problems or trauma. Get real assistance if you need it.

However, this book will provide you with tools for the interim - the regular times when you're stuck and need to make a better move.

Make use of these plays. Take note of what functions. Over time, create your own version of this toolkit.

This is something you can do.